



THE BATTLE BEGINS: Last respects being paid to Benazir; (right) a pensive Musharraf

A lethal cocktail of despotism, assassination and martyrdom saw Pakistan plunge into chaos and stall progress on the peace process with India

the Government's predicament when he said, "There are three options before the Government. The Government stays on and no deal; no Government but nuclear deal and no Government and no nuclear deal. It's up to the Government to decide." Reflecting the Government's dilemma, Congress spokesman Abhishek Manu Singhvi stated, "We believe that the nuclear deal is good for the country but if you have no government, is there a way to get the deal operationalised? We believe that there is no need to face death and have no martyrdom."

Meanwhile, a lethal cocktail of death, martyrdom and despotism stalled any progress in the peace process with Pakistan. Thankfully though, India and Manmohan were not to blame. Pakistan President Pervez Musharraf in a bid to ensure his survivability entered into a dangerous path of confrontation against his political opponents and the judiciary. In a major blunder, he sacked Supreme Court Chief Justice Iftekhar Chaudhry and other judges and declared a state of Emergency on November 3. Under pressure, he took half a U-turn by taking off his uniform, lifting the Emergency on December 16 and announcing that parliamentary elections would be held in January. But he maintained that his re-election as president was legally valid and also refused to restore the judiciary. His arch-rivals, the



Lavrov failing to meet Mukherjee in Moscow signalled a Russian chill